

MSP | MSP-15

Assurance Approach and Plan

Independent assurance across the three lines

Meridian Group

Programme Helios — Infrastructure and Platform Stack for AI GPU Compute at Scale

Field	Detail
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Date	18 Sep 2026
Author	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager
Owner	Senior Responsible Owner
Approver	Sponsoring Group
Classification	Internal
Retention	7 years from programme closure

Document control

Version history

Version	Date	Author	Summary of change
0.1	04 Jun 2026	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager	Initial draft
0.2	21 Jul 2026	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager	Updated following workstream lead review
1.0	18 Sep 2026	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager	Baselined at the Tranche 2 funding gate

Reviewers

Name	Role	Review scope	Date reviewed
T. Nakamura, Chief Platform Architect	Chief Platform Architect	Technical content and solution alignment	08 Sep 2026
L. Haddad, CISO	CISO	Security, assurance and residency content	10 Sep 2026
C. Whitfield, Finance Business Partner	Finance Business Partner	Cost, funding and benefit figures	11 Sep 2026
M. Verity, Head of P3O	Head of P3O	Governance standards and completeness	15 Sep 2026

Approval

This product is baselined once approval is recorded below. Any subsequent change must go through change control.

Name	Role	Decision	Date
R. Al Mazrouei, Group CTO	Senior Responsible Owner / Group CTO	Approved	18 Sep 2026
H. Farrell, Director of Infrastructure	Director of Infrastructure	Approved	18 Sep 2026
L. Haddad, CISO	CISO	Approved subject to closure of ISS-003	18 Sep 2026

Related products

Reference	Product	Relationship
MSP-11	Programme Governance Approach	Governance context
MSP-21	End of Tranche Review Report	A key assurance point

How to use this template

Aspect	Guidance
Purpose	Defines how confidence in the programme will be obtained independently of those delivering it, covering the scope, timing, and independence of assurance activity.
Framework	MSP — Assurance theme; created in Define the Programme
Created when	Define the Programme
Reviewed / updated	At each tranche boundary
Owner	Senior Responsible Owner
Approver	Sponsoring Group
Format options	Document, presentation, register entry, or tool record — the content matters, not the medium.
Tailoring	Scale the depth of each section to the scale, risk and complexity of the work. Delete sections that add no value and record the tailoring decision in the governance approach.

This is a worked example. Every field has been completed with illustrative content for Programme Helios, a fictional AI GPU infrastructure and platform programme. All example content is shown in grey italic — the black text is the template itself. Replace the grey italic content with your own.

Quality criteria

Use these to check the product is fit for purpose before submitting it for approval.

- Assurance providers are independent of the activity they assure
- Assurance is scheduled ahead of decision points, not after them
- Findings have an owner, a due date, and a follow-up mechanism
- Duplication between assurance providers is deliberately managed

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1. Assurance objectives and principles

Security is treated as a design participant rather than a reviewer. The controls that matter most are tenant isolation at namespace and network policy level, per-tenant key management, a signed container image supply chain with admission enforcement, firmware attestation at node admission, and brokered vendor access through a monitored in-country jump host. Independent penetration testing is scheduled at 30% build and again before multi-tenant go-live.

2. Three lines of assurance

Line	Provider	Scope	Reports to	Frequency
First line — management	Sable Talent Partners	<i>In scope: the physical infrastructure in DXB-1 halls A and B, the compute and storage estate, the network fabric, the orchestration and scheduling platform, the MLOps and developer experience layer, the security controls required for multi-tenancy, and the operational readiness required to run the estate. Out of scope: the models themselves, business-unit data engineering, the AUH-2 second site (Tranche 3), and any change to the existing corporate WAN.</i>	C. Whitfield, Finance Business Partner	Each iteration
Second line — oversight	Cordant Assurance	<i>In scope: the physical infrastructure in DXB-1 halls A and B, the compute and storage estate, the network fabric, the orchestration and scheduling platform, the MLOps and developer experience layer, the security controls required for multi-tenancy, and the operational readiness required to run the estate. Out of scope: the models themselves, business-unit data engineering, the AUH-2 second site (Tranche 3), and any change to the existing corporate WAN.</i>	B. Oyelaran, Quality and Assurance Lead	Fortnightly
Third line — independent audit	Yes	<i>In scope: the physical infrastructure in DXB-1 halls A and B, the compute and storage estate, the network fabric, the orchestration and scheduling platform, the MLOps and developer experience layer, the security controls required for multi-tenancy, and the operational</i>	Partially	Each planning interval

Line	Provider	Scope	Reports to	Frequency
		<i>readiness required to run the estate. Out of scope: the models themselves, business-unit data engineering, the AUH-2 second site (Tranche 3), and any change to the existing corporate WAN.</i>		

3. Assurance schedule

Ref	Assurance activity	Type	Scope	Provider	Timing	Decision supported
AS-01	Execute floor strengthening works	Facilities	Facilities, power and cooling works within the Tranche 2 boundary	Parallel storage vendor	31 Mar 2027	Rejected
AS-02	Place structural strengthening order	Security	DXB-1 halls A and B, 2,048 accelerators and the supporting fabric and storage	Cordant Assurance	23 Apr 2027	Deferred to the next Board
AS-03	Complete hall B structural survey	Commercial	The three onboarding tenants and their committed migration workloads	Sable Talent Partners	28 May 2027	Approved with conditions
AS-04	Onboard three tenants and confirm quota enforcement	Organisational	Excludes AUH-2, model development and business-unit data engineering	Accelerator vendor (direct)	25 Jun 2027	Approved

4. Assurance activity types

Type	Description	When used
Gate review	Independent review at a defined decision point	28 May 2027
Health check	Point-in-time assessment of programme condition	31 Mar 2027
Deep dive	Focused review of a specific area of concern	15 Dec 2026
Benefits assurance	Validation of benefit claims and measurement	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation
Technical assurance	Review of architecture, security or solution design	26 Feb 2027
Compliance audit	Assessment against policy or regulatory obligation	31 Mar 2027

5. Assurance criteria

What each assurance activity will test the programme against.

Activity ref	Criteria	Evidence required	Rating scheme
Rack, cable and burn-in accelerators	Independent penetration test closed with no open critical or high findings	Solution intent wiki, DXB-1 platform space	Independent penetration test closed with no open critical or high findings
Receive and firmware-verify accelerator shipment	Fair-share quota holds within 5% for each tenant under contention	ALM tool — Helios ART board	All-reduce efficiency at or above 92% on three consecutive 256-GPU runs
Tune congestion control and benchmark NCCL	Median environment request-to-usable time under two hours across 20 sampled requests	Assurance evidence pack, Tranche 2 gate	Storage sustains 1.2 TB/s against a representative training corpus for 30 minutes
Build leaf-spine fabric in hall A	Storage sustains 1.2 TB/s against a representative training corpus for 30 minutes	Configuration management database	Median environment request-to-usable time under two hours across 20 sampled requests

6. Independence and conflicts

How independence is preserved, and how any conflict of interest is declared and managed.

Programme Helios — Tranche 2 scale build, DXB-1 halls A and B. Scoped to the three onboarding tenants: AI Research, Fraud Analytics and Retail. Detail is maintained by the Senior Responsible Owner and reviewed at the monthly Programme Board.

7. Findings and actions register

Ref	Source review	Finding	Rating	Recommendation	Owner	Due	Status
FAA-01	23 Apr 2027	On plan; no intervention required this period	Enforce mutual TLS on the cluster API and retest by 22 Sep 2026	31 Jan 2027	V. Chandra, Head of AI Enablement	30 Nov 2026	Not started

Ref	Source review	Finding	Rating	Recommendation	Owner	Due	Status
FAA-02	31 Mar 2027	Amber — recovery action agreed with the workstream lead and tracked weekly	Retune CDU set-points and model a secondary heat rejection loop	15 Dec 2026	J. Ferreira, Network Lead	15 Oct 2026	Open
FAA-03	26 Feb 2027	Dependent on the Enterprise Identity Programme; outside programme control	Confirm vendor allocation in writing before placing the structural order	30 Nov 2026	I. Petrova, Data Platform Lead	18 Sep 2026	In progress
FAA-04	31 Jan 2027	Escalated to the Programme Board on 18 Sep 2026; decision requested	Secure written migration commitments from three business units	15 Oct 2026	K. Adeyemi, Security Architect	25 Jun 2027	Complete

8. Reporting of assurance outcomes

Report	Audience	Content	Frequency
Tranche 2 gate evidence pack	Programme Manager and workstream leads	Multi-tenant orchestration with fair-share quota across AI Research, Fraud Analytics and Retail	Quarterly
Weekly workstream status return	Programme Board	Parallel filesystem tier of 12 PB usable sustaining 1.2 TB/s to the compute estate	Monthly
Programme Board pack	Agile Release Train — all teams	Multi-tenant orchestration with fair-share quota across AI Research, Fraud Analytics and Retail	At each stage boundary
ART sync record	Service Operations and	400G RoCEv2 leaf-spine fabric tuned	Each iteration

Report	Audience	Content	Frequency
	FM provider	for collective communication at 256-GPU job scale	

9. Cost and resourcing of assurance

Activity	Provider	Cost	Funded by
Deploy scheduling and quota platform	Nexora Integration Services	AED 1,080,000 per year	Confirmed at the Tranche 1 end-of-tranche review, 18 Sep 2026
Implement signed image supply chain and admission control	Accelerator vendor (direct)	AED 1,440,000 per year	Enforced automatically in the delivery pipeline, with evidence retained
Independent penetration test and remediation	Sable Talent Partners	AED 460,000 per year	Reported through the monthly benefit tracking report
Onboard three tenants and confirm quota enforcement	Cordant Assurance	AED 2,100,000 per year	Owned within WS4 Platform and orchestration
Complete hall B structural survey	Parallel storage vendor	AED 890,000	Maintained by the P3O as part of the assurance evidence library